

Claude Skills cheat sheet

Everything you need on one page — structure, naming, descriptions, checklist

What's a skill?

A skill is a text file that teaches Claude a new ability. You write the instructions, upload the file, and Claude follows them whenever someone asks for that task.

Folder structure

```
my-skill-name/      <- kebab-case (lowercase, hyphens)
  ■■■ SKILL.md      <- your instructions (required)
  ■■■ scripts/      <- code that runs automatically (optional)
    ■ ■■■ validate.py
  ■■■ references/    <- extra docs Claude reads when needed (optional)
    ■ ■■■ api-patterns.md
  ■■■ assets/        <- templates, icons, fonts (optional)
```

SKILL.md anatomy

Every skill file has two parts: the **frontmatter** (a label at the top) and the **body** (your instructions).

```
---                <- required
name: my-skill-name  <- kebab-case
description: What it does.  <- MOST IMPORTANT FIELD
  Use when user says "...".  <- trigger phrases
---                <- required

# Skill Title

## Instructions
(step-by-step workflow)

## Examples
(realistic input -> output)

## Troubleshooting
(specific errors -> specific fixes)
```

How to write the description

The description is the most important field — it determines whether Claude uses your skill or ignores it.

[What it does] + [what it works with].

Use when user says "[phrase 1]", "[phrase 2]", "[phrase 3]".

Do NOT use for [out-of-scope thing].

Pre-upload checklist

#	Check	Why it matters
1	File named exactly SKILL.md	Claude looks for this exact name
2	--- delimiters on top and bottom of frontmatter	Without them, the file won't parse
3	No < or > in frontmatter	Angle brackets break the system
4	Name doesn't contain "claude" or "anthropic"	These are reserved words
5	Name is kebab-case	my-skill not my_skill or My Skill
6	Description has 3+ trigger phrases	Claude needs to know when to activate
7	Has negative triggers where needed	"Do NOT use for..." prevents false matches
8	Instructions are numbered steps	Specific beats vague, every time
9	Error handling is specific	"Errors are handled" is not enough
10	SKILL.md under 500 lines	Move large content to references/

Quick fixes

Problem	Likely cause	Fix
Won't upload	Wrong filename or missing ---	Check SKILL.md casing + delimiters
Never triggers	Description too vague	Add phrases users would actually type
Triggers on everything	Description too broad	Add "Do NOT use for..."
Triggers but bad output	Vague instructions	Add numbered steps with specific actions
MCP calls fail	No error handling	Add specific error → solution for each call
Inconsistent output	No output template	Show Claude what "done" looks like
Claude ignores important rules	Critical info is buried	Move it to the top

How Claude loads skills

Claude doesn't read everything at once. It loads in layers:

Layer	What	When
1. Metadata	Name + description	Always visible to Claude

Layer	What	When
2. SKILL.md body	Your instructions	When the skill triggers
3. References	Extra docs, API patterns	When your instructions say to read them
Scripts	Validation, automation code	Executed on demand, not loaded into memory

MCP quick reference

If your skill connects to external tools:

- **Check connection first** — verify MCP is connected before calling any tools
- **List it in metadata** — `mcp-server: linear`
- **Degrade gracefully** — if MCP is down, do what you can without it
- **Name exact tools** — "Use Linear MCP: `create_issue`"
- **Handle auth errors** — "Reconnect in Settings → Extensions"